IOWN

The Morning Brief

APRIL 25, 2026

Records Hold

Intel's blowout lifts the chip tape to an 18-session win streak and the S&P closes the week at a record; Witkoff and Kushner head to Pakistan with the ceasefire window narrowing.

S&P 500 (FRI CLOSE)	NASDAQ (FRI CLOSE)	BRENT CRUDE (FRI)	BITCOIN (LIVE)	FEAR & GREED
7,165 ↑0.6% on the week	24,837 ↑1.5% on the week	~$105 · Range held above $100	~$77,500 · Stalled below $80K	39 · Fear

SECTION 01

Markets — Week in Review

AI REASSERTED LEADERSHIP INTO THE CLOSE — RECORDS RESTORED ON AN INTEL BLOWOUT

The week traced a clean arc: Wednesday's records, Thursday's oil-driven retracement, and Friday's reassertion as Intel's post-close blowout (EPS $0.29 vs. $0.02, revenue $13.6B vs. $12.4B) lifted the entire AI complex. The S&P 500 closed Friday at 7,165, the Nasdaq at 24,837 — both fresh records. Per Yahoo and CNBC, the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index extended its win streak to 18 consecutive sessions, with the cohort leading the broader market through April. Nvidia reclaimed the $5 trillion market-cap mark. Per Benzinga, AMD jumped 13.91% and QCOM advanced 11.12% on Friday alone — the AI-CPU and analog cohorts that anchor the IOWN growth sleeve carried the week. The Dow lagged at −0.4% on the week, reflecting the dispersion: defensives compounded steadily, semis re-rated, and the cyclical industrial cohort gave back ground.

S&P 500	7,165 · ↑0.6% on the week · Record close
NASDAQ	24,837 · ↑1.5% on the week · Record close
DOW JONES	↓0.4% on the week
SOX (SEMIS)	18-session win streak · ↑~10% on the week
NVIDIA / INTEL	NVDA reclaims $5T cap · INTC ↑23.6% Friday
BRENT CRUDE	~$105 · Range held above $100 all week
CARSON'S SPY SUPPORT	$645.80 · Untouched · ~9% below Friday close

MICHIGAN SENTIMENT PRINTED A RECORD LOW — THE CONSUMER CRACKED EVEN AS EQUITIES RE-RATED

The University of Michigan's final April reading came in at 49.8, revised up from the 47.6 preliminary print but still the lowest level on record — below the financial crisis, the COVID trough, and the post-Ukraine inflation spike per the press release. One-year inflation expectations jumped to 4.7% from 3.8% prior, the largest one-month increase since April 2025; five-year expectations climbed to 3.5%, the highest since October 2025. The disconnect between equity records and consumer psychology is the clearest tell of the regime: the AI-led tape and the war-inflation transmission are running on parallel tracks. For the FOMC's April 28–29 meeting, the inflation-expectations breakout reinforces the higher-for-longer path that markets are now pricing through late 2026 per CME FedWatch.

A weekly close at fresh records on AI leadership, with Michigan inflation expectations breaking out and Brent holding above $100, captures the regime cleanly: the physical-AI thesis and the energy-inflation thread are repricing together, not against each other. **The physical world matters.**

SECTION 02

Geopolitics

WITKOFF AND KUSHNER HEAD TO PAKISTAN — THE NEGOTIATING CHANNEL REOPENS AS THE CEASEFIRE WINDOW NARROWS

The White House confirmed Friday that Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner are traveling to Islamabad on Saturday for what the administration is framing as "direct talks" with Iran, per CBS News and CNBC. Vice President Vance, who led the failed first round, will remain on standby in Washington. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi arrived in Islamabad late Friday and met with Pakistan's foreign minister per Times of Israel. The signals from Tehran are mixed: an Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson stated "no meeting is planned" between Iran and the United States, with Pakistan to convey observations — per Al Jazeera. If taken at face value, Iran's posture is consistent with a mediated rather than direct dialogue, which would prolong rather than resolve the standoff. The two-week ceasefire is set to expire over the weekend, which is what gives the Pakistan track its catalyst weight into Monday's open.

THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ STAYS SHUT — BRENT HELD ABOVE $100 DESPITE THE NEGOTIATING TRACK

Brent crude settled Friday at roughly $105.30 per barrel, little changed on the session per The National, with WTI giving back 1.5% to $94.40 on the U.S. inventory build. The wedge between Brent and WTI — consistent with a supply premium concentrated in the global cargo trade rather than U.S. pipelines — widened on the week. Per CNBC, the Strait remained shut as both sides continued ship-seizure activity. The longer the corridor stays closed, the greater the cumulative economic cost to both sides — a structure that historically forces a resolution but does not prescribe its timing or terms. For IOWN's energy sleeve (CVX, VLO, OKE, CTRA, CNX), the elevated Brent handle has held a higher trading range for a third consecutive week. The materials sleeve (FCX, AEM, NTR, STLD) continues to trade with the dollar/rate path more than with the conflict tape.

THE FOMC MEETS TUESDAY-WEDNESDAY — POWELL'S LAST MEETING INTO A HOTTER INFLATION PATH

The FOMC convenes April 28–29 with markets pricing approximately 99.5% probability of no change per Polymarket and roughly 94% per CME FedWatch. The federal funds target range remains 3.50–3.75%. The March dot plot showed a median of one cut for 2026, but seven committee members projected zero cuts — and the path of least resistance moves further hawkish given Friday's Michigan inflation-expectations breakout, the war-driven energy shock, and resilient labor data (March payrolls 178K, unemployment 4.3%). This is Powell's final FOMC meeting and press conference. The Warsh confirmation track remains stalled per prior coverage, with Senator Tillis conditioning his committee vote on closure of the Powell investigation. The risk-management implication is asymmetric: the meeting itself may be uneventful, but the press conference is the last opportunity for Powell to anchor the policy framework before the chair transition uncertainty lands. *For IOWN, the higher-for-longer regime continues to favor pricing-power names in the dividend sleeve.*

PAKISTAN TALKS	**Witkoff & Kushner travel Saturday · Vance on standby**
IRAN POSTURE	**FM Araghchi in Islamabad · "No meeting planned" per Tehran spokesperson**
HORMUZ	**Stays shut · Both sides continue ship-seizure activity**
BRENT / WTI SPREAD	**Brent ~$105.30 · WTI $94.40 · Cargo premium widened**
MICHIGAN FINAL	**49.8 · Lowest on record · 1Y infl. expects 4.7%**
FOMC	**April 28–29 · Powell's last meeting · ~99.5% no change priced**

SECTION 03

On Our Radar

1. Week Ahead: The most consequential macro-and-earnings combination of the cycle. Tuesday-Wednesday brings the FOMC decision and Powell's final press conference. Microsoft and Alphabet report Tuesday after the close; Meta reports Wednesday after the FOMC decision; Amazon and Apple report Thursday after the close. Q1 GDP and the March PCE deflator land in the same window. None of these mega-caps are direct IOWN holdings, but the AI-capex commentary will set the tone for the semiconductor complex IOWN holds heavily — NVDA, AMD, TSM, MRVL, NXPI, ADI, LRCX, KEYS, QCOM, CRDO. PCAR is the IOWN reporter on the calendar and prints into a heavy-truck cycle that the Friday-tape's industrial laggard rotation is testing. Position sizing into the FOMC window matters more than direction. *Research Reveals Opportunities.*

2. Pakistan Talks — The Single Highest-Variance Weekend Catalyst. Three plausible outcomes: a constructive readout that opens Monday with Brent retracing toward the low-$90s and a broad risk-on bid in cyclicals; an inconclusive readout that maintains the current range with Brent holding above $100; or a collapse that opens Monday with an energy-premium gap-up and a broad risk-off rotation back toward Thursday's defensive complex. The asymmetry tilts slightly toward the inconclusive base case given Iran's public posture that Pakistan would convey observations rather than direct talks. The IOWN sleeve geometry handles each scenario differently — energy (CVX, VLO, OKE, CTRA) leans into the third path, the AI-semis complex into the first, and the dividend compounders (NEE, ATO, BKH, CL, CHD, STLD) hold their own across all three. *Avoid Erosion.*

3. The Semiconductor 18-Session Win Streak Is the Cleanest Tape Signal of the Year. Per BBN Times and Yahoo, the Philadelphia Semiconductor Index has now risen in 18 consecutive sessions and has been the clear leadership cohort through April. The breadth of the move — analog (NXPI, ADI), test (KEYS), capital equipment (LRCX), AI compute (NVDA, AMD), foundry (TSM), networking (MRVL, CRDO) — suggests this is a regime re-rating rather than a single-name story. Two structural questions sit underneath: how much of the Intel beat is durable share recapture versus AI-driven cycle pull-forward, and whether the sentiment momentum can absorb a hawkish FOMC press conference. Historically, win streaks of this length have ended on macro shocks rather than fundamental disappointment. The committee may want to assess whether portfolio-level semi exposure has crept above target through the move. *Think Like an Owner.*

4. Earnings Reset — The IOWN Through-Line From the Week. Five IOWN names reported through Thursday: NEE delivered a clean beat with raised guidance and rallied 6.94%; FCX beat but sold off 12.62% as the cycle's upside was already priced in; LMT missed at $6.44 vs. $6.77 with weaker free cash flow; SSNC posted a narrow beat; ORI missed at $0.68 vs. $0.80. The pattern is consistent with prior briefs: in this regime, the tape rewards acceleration and durable cash conversion, not delivery. Friday's broad-market rally on Intel's data-center beat reframes the AI-capex demand read constructively for the IOWN semiconductor complex into next week's mega-cap reports. The earnings tape and the macro tape are now running on the same axis — AI-CPU and physical-AI infrastructure spending is the unifying thread. **The physical world matters.**

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